

Major ideas and concepts in design

When designing our project's website our aim was to focus on implementing the ideas and concepts we learned in class into our design in the best way possible. There were a couple of ideas that were taught in class that we included in our design, some of which are:

1- Enhance User Experience: While building our design, one of the most important key concepts in design was always at the back of our minds. This was the fact that we need to understand that we are not the user, and that we need to build a design that fulfills the needs of the user before anyone else. For example, we understood that a user of the OSICAN website will likely be part of the target demographic that the website serves (someone with PTSD or a work related stress injury). A user like that might need resources that fit their needs, hence why we created a search integrated design for the resources where the user can easily enter a name of a resource and find it instantly. Another thing regarding design is the color template of our design, which initially we agreed to making it red across the whole website. Then after our customer check-in with Julius he told us that a colour like that might be too "intense" for a user of OSICAN. That's why we took Julius's recommendations and made the color template of our design a light blue. In gathering customer insights and listening to their outlook on things we were able to create the design we have today.

2- Knowledge Of The Head and The World: When creating our design we understood that users already have previous knowledge about things in the world and our aim as designers is to understand that knowledge, where it came from and why it's there in order to include it in our design. For example, in our FAQ section we included an arrow at the end of our question box, which signifies that if the user pressed the arrow the answer would appear.

3- Affordances and Signifiers: Affordances are all the possible actions that a user is able to complete with an object or design. They rely on both the functions of the object/design and the abilities of the user. On the other hand, signifiers are what signals to the user that there is a potential action to be made. These have been utilized throughout our project conceptualization and work. Since the beginning of this project, our group has made an effort to ensure that a user knows when a design is interactable and that they are actually able to interact with it. An example of this is the site's buttons. Their ability is that they can be pressed. A user will likely be able to press them, since they are relatively big and provide a lot of clickable space. Its signifiers are that it is an oval that contrasts well with the background, it has text such as "More Information" that suggests something will happen when pressed, and they change colour when hovered over. Other signifiers on our current work include the magnifying glass to suggest the location of a search function, the social media symbols, and the folder function on the individual event and program pages.